

DRIVING SYSTEMS, POLICY & INNOVATION FOR STROKE CARE IN INDIA

A flagship initiative by Voice of Healthcare focused on transforming stroke care systems.

In India. India's stroke care ecosystem is at a defining moment. With nearly 1.8–2 million new stroke cases reported every year and less than 15% of patients reaching hospitals within the critical golden treatment window, stroke continues to remain one of the leading causes of death and long-term disability in the country. Beyond being a medical emergency, stroke today represents a larger systems challenge—one that demands stronger infrastructure, improved awareness, rapid emergency response, and integrated long-term care pathways.

Against this backdrop, the **VOH National Stroke Conclave 2026, endorsed by the Indian Stroke Association and supported by the India Hypertension Control Initiative and Yatharth Super Speciality Hospitals,** brought together some of India's leading neurologists, policymakers, healthcare administrators, public health experts, and innovators at The Lalit, New Delhi. The conclave, an initiative by Voice of Healthcare, focused on driving implementation-oriented discussions around strengthening stroke care systems across India.

The inaugural session set the tone for the day with powerful insights from experts across clinical, policy, and public health domains. **Dr. Nishchal Naveen, Founder, Voice of Healthcare,** highlighted the pressing infrastructure gaps that continue to affect stroke outcomes, especially in smaller cities and underserved regions.

"There remains a significant gap in stroke care across tier 3 cities, driven by a shortage of neurologists and specialised infrastructure. While telehealth and digital technologies can help bridge this divide, the reality is that many regions still lack even basic facilities like CT scan machines. During my time managing hospitals in tier 2 and tier 3 cities, ensuring access to CT imaging was a priority—but scaling that level of infrastructure across all cities remains a major challenge," he noted.

Highlighting the scale and urgency of the crisis, **Dr. Vikram Huded, President, Indian Stroke Association,** emphasized that India's healthcare systems must evolve rapidly to address growing stroke burden.

"India records nearly 1.8 million stroke cases annually, yet access to timely treatment remains critically limited. Fewer than 5% of eligible patients receive thrombolysis — a stark indicator of the gaps that continue to exist in acute stroke care delivery," he stated.

He further stressed that India's stroke response systems are still not adequately optimized for rapid intervention. "An integrated stroke care pathway — from early recognition and emergency transport to definitive treatment — is no longer optional; it is essential. Strengthening emergency response systems, including GPS-enabled ambulance networks and faster triage mechanisms, will be key to reducing time-to-treatment and improving outcomes. At the same time, public awareness around stroke symptoms remains insufficient, and improving early recognition can save countless lives."

Adding to this, **Dr. Arvind Sharma, Secretary, Indian Stroke Association,** emphasized the importance of coordinated action and collaborative healthcare ecosystems.

"Advancing stroke care in India demands the convergence of innovation, strategic partnerships, and supportive policy. Effective stroke care cannot be delivered in silos — it requires a coordinated ecosystem where clinicians, policymakers, healthcare institutions, emergency responders, and technology providers work together in concert," he said.

He also highlighted the importance of standardization and equitable access. "Establishing standardized SOPs for advanced stroke centres is a critical step toward ensuring consistent, high-quality care. However, stroke care must also extend